For the Love of Cinema:
A Review of *Cinema Paradiso* (1988)

Kusali Rupasinghe

The Director



Giuseppe Tornatore (born 1956) is one of Italy's most acclaimed filmmakers, known for creating emotionally rich and visually memorable films. Born in Sicily, many of his works reflect his own experiences of growing up in small Italian towns. His international reputation was established with *Cinema Paradiso* (1988), which won the Academy Award for Best Foreign Language Film and the Grand Prix at the Cannes Film Festival. Tornatore is recognised for combining nostalgia, human relationships, and storytelling in his films. He has also directed notable films such as *Everybody's Fine*, *The Legend of 1900*, *Malèna*, *Baarìa*, and *The Best Offer*. His long-standing collaboration with composer Ennio Morricone has greatly enriched his cinematic style.

The Movie



Cinema Paradiso (*Nuovo Cinema Paradiso*) is a 1988 Italian coming-of-age drama written and directed by Giuseppe Tornatore. Set in a small Sicilian town after the Second World War, the film follows the life of Salvatore "Toto" Di Vita from childhood to adulthood. Through his friendship with the elderly projectionist Alfredo, Toto develops a lifelong love for cinema that eventually leads him to become a successful filmmaker. The film explores memory, friendship, loss, community, and the magic of cinema. Widely regarded as a masterpiece of world cinema, it won several international awards and continues to be admired for its emotional storytelling and unforgettable musical score by Ennio and Andrea Morricone.

The Review by Kusali Rupasinghe

Movies have been an integral part of my life since I was a kid.

I don't think I have enough words to describe my love for cinema. My earliest memory of watching movies is when I was about six years old. During the school holidays, I'd get up early in the morning to watch movies broadcasted on local TV channels. My father, who loves movies just as much as I do, used to bring CDs, and my siblings and I would watch them all day. Looking back, some of my happiest moments have been watching movies with my siblings and family. I believe this is why *Cinema Paradiso* (also known as *Nuovo Cinema Paradiso*) is one of my favourite movies ever.

I'm not exaggerating when I say that the 1988 Italian movie *Cinema Paradiso*, is one of the best movies I've ever seen. I am clearly not alone in my opinion—the film regularly appears in “best movies of all time" lists and went on to win the Academy Award for Best Foreign Language Film in 1989. Written and directed by Giuseppe Tornatore, the film is a love letter to cinema.

Cinema Paradiso explores the life of Salvatore Di Vita (nicknamed Toto) in his boyhood, teenage years, and adulthood. The film begins with Adult Toto (Jacques Perrin), now a famous filmmaker receiving a call from his mother saying that his mentor and father figure, Alfredo, has passed away. Through flashbacks, the audience is shown Toto as a child (Salvatore Cascio) and a teenager (Marco Leonardi).

Set in Giancaldo, a small town in Sicily, Toto forms a friendship with the town's titular cinema theatre's projectionist, Alfredo (Philippe Noiret). While watching a movie, young Toto is fascinated by the little hole in the wall from where Alfredo projects the film. Toto has already fallen in love with watching movies (at one point, his mother bans him from watching movies after he spends all the milk money on them), and he begs Alfredo to teach him. At first, Alfredo is reluctant, but Toto manages to change his mind. This is the start of a beautiful relationship. Toto, who lost his father in the Second World War, finds a father figure in Alfredo. From his young days to his teenage years, Alfredo becomes an unwavering pillar of support to Toto. He gives him life advice, teaches everything he knows, and encourages him to leave the town and pursue his dreams in Rome.

Tornatore wrote the script based on his childhood town’s cinema theatre and his love for cinema. The screenplay is witty and gives life to so many interesting characters that are fascinating to watch. Some of them are; the town priest-who comes with a bell to the theatre and rings whenever there's a kissing scene so that Alfredo will cut them

before projecting them to the people, the man who lives in the main square and yells at people claiming it's "(his) square", and the character who recites all the lines by memory and the man who sleeps during films and the people who try to wake him up. Just as it is a love letter to cinema, Tornatore wanted the film to be a tribute to cinema theatres. In Giancaldo, people come in droves to watch movies with their babies and children in tow. It is a joyful sight to see; they yell, laugh, and bond as a community while watching a movie. Some meet at the theatre and fall in love. One of my favourite scenes is when the town sees a kiss on screen for the first time, and the crowd goes bonkers! It is important to remember the film is set in a time when people are grieving after the events of the Second World War, so watching movies together is also healing to them. This goes on to show how films can heal and bring people together.

A special mention should be given to Ennio Morricone's moving score. It is heart-rendering and achingly beautiful. Even as I write this, I can hear it in my mind. I want this review to be spoiler-free, so I will not go into details, but I believe *Cinema Paradiso* has one of cinema's most moving and memorable endings. I was sobbing by the end of it.

I think the word "masterpiece" is often thrown around when describing films, but Cinema Paradiso in particular deserves to be called one. It explores man's strong connection to cinema, nostalgia, loss, love, and childhood magnificently. Watching this reminded me of myself when I was little, waking up early in the morning to watch movies. *Cinema Paradiso* is a must-see for every movie lover.

Major Themes of the Film

1. Love for Cinema

The film celebrates cinema as a powerful medium of storytelling and imagination. It portrays the cinema hall as a place where people gather to experience joy, sorrow, and hope together.

2. Nostalgia and Memory

The story is built around Adult Toto's memories of childhood. It explores how the past continues to shape personal identity and reminds us that childhood memories remain an important part of our lives.

3. Mentorship and Friendship

The relationship between Toto and Alfredo demonstrates the importance of guidance, trust, and encouragement. Alfredo's influence helps Toto discover his passion and pursue his dreams.

4. Community

The Cinema Paradiso theatre serves as the social centre of the town, bringing together people of different ages and backgrounds. The film highlights cinema as a shared cultural experience.

5. Growing Up and Leaving Home

Toto's journey from childhood to adulthood reflects the challenges of pursuing one's ambitions. The film shows that achieving success often requires leaving familiar surroundings while carrying cherished memories of home.

6. Healing Through Art

Set in post-war Italy, the film presents cinema as a source of comfort and healing for a community recovering from loss and hardship.

Main Characters

Salvatore "Toto" Di Vita



The protagonist of the film, Toto is shown as a child, a teenager, and an adult. Curious and imaginative, he develops a deep passion for cinema, which shapes his future career as a filmmaker. His journey represents personal growth, ambition, and the bittersweet experience of remembering one's past.

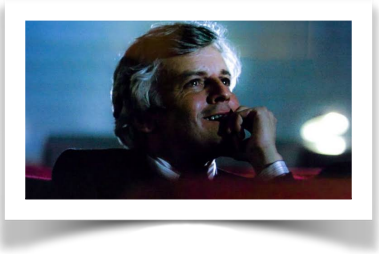
Alfredo



Alfredo is the projectionist of the Cinema Paradiso theatre and Toto's mentor. Wise, humorous, and compassionate, he teaches Toto both the technical skills of film projection and valuable lessons about life. Having lost his father during the war, Toto finds in Alfredo a loving father figure whose guidance

profoundly influences his future.

Adult Salvatore



As an accomplished filmmaker living in Rome, Adult Toto returns to his hometown after Alfredo's death. His return triggers memories of childhood and prompts reflection on the passage of time, the importance of home, and the enduring influence of the past.

Elena



Elena is Toto's first love during his teenage years. Their relationship represents youthful romance, hope, and disappointment, while also contributing to Toto's emotional development as he moves toward adulthood.

Supporting Characters

The film also features several memorable townspeople, including the parish priest who censors kissing scenes by ringing a bell, the eccentric man who claims ownership of the town square, and the lively cinema audience. These characters create a vivid picture of community life and contribute to the film's humour and realism.

Kusali Rupasinghe's Review of *Cinema Paradiso*

The film review by Kusali Rupasinghe, **"For the Love of Cinema,"** is an engaging and thoughtful appreciation of *Cinema Paradiso* that combines personal reflection with critical analysis. She begins by recalling her own childhood memories of watching films with her family, immediately creating an emotional connection with the reader. She then introduces the film's background, its director, and its international recognition before providing a concise, spoiler-free summary of the story. Rather than merely narrating the plot, she highlights the film's central themes, such as nostalgia, friendship, community, and the healing power of cinema. The review also pays attention to memorable characters, the vibrant atmosphere of the cinema hall, and Ennio Morricone's moving musical score. It concludes with a balanced evaluation, describing the film as a masterpiece while explaining the reasons for this judgement. Rupasinghe's review demonstrates that a good movie review combines factual information, personal response, careful observation, thematic analysis, and clear, persuasive writing, making it both informative and engaging.

Multiple Choice Questions

1. What is the primary setting of *Cinema Paradiso*?

A. A bustling city in Rome
B. A small Sicilian town named Giancaldo
C. A village in northern France
D. A coastal town in Spain

2. What role does Alfredo play in Toto's life?

A. He is Toto's schoolteacher.
B. He is Toto's elder brother.
C. He becomes Toto's mentor and father figure.
D. He is a famous film director.

3. According to Kusali Rupasinghe's review, what makes *Cinema Paradiso* a "love letter to cinema"?

A. It focuses mainly on filmmaking technology.
B. It celebrates the joy, nostalgia, and communal experience of watching films.
C. It criticises modern cinema and television.
D. It tells the history of Italian cinema in detail.

4. In the film, what does the priest do whenever a kissing scene appears on the screen?

A. He leaves the cinema hall.
B. He applauds the audience.
C. He rings a bell to have the scene censored.
D. He stops the film permanently.

5. Which of the following qualities of Kusali Rupasinghe's review best demonstrates effective movie review writing?

A. Revealing the entire ending of the film
B. Focusing only on the plot without analysis

C. Combining personal memories with critical evaluation and avoiding spoilers
D. Criticising every aspect of the film without evidence

6. Which major theme is most strongly conveyed through Toto's return to Giancaldo after Alfredo's death?

A. Political revolution
B. Scientific progress
C. Nostalgia and the lasting influence of childhood memories
D. Competition in the film industry

Answer Keys: 1. B; 2. C; 3. B; 4. C; 5. C; 6. C.

Short Answer Questions

1. How does the relationship between Toto and Alfredo influence Toto's life?

Answer Hint: Alfredo serves as Toto's mentor and father figure. He teaches him about cinema, offers guidance in life, and encourages him to leave Giancaldo to pursue his dreams and achieve success.

2. Why is the Cinema Paradiso theatre important to the people of Giancaldo?

Answer Hint: The cinema acts as a communal gathering place where people laugh, cry, socialize, and temporarily escape the hardships of post-war life. It brings the community together through shared experiences.

3. How does Kusali Rupasinghe make her review of *Cinema Paradiso* engaging for readers?

Answer Hint: She combines personal childhood memories with information about the film, discusses its themes and characters, and shares her emotional response while avoiding spoilers.

4. What does the film suggest about memory and nostalgia?

Answer Hint: The film shows that childhood memories remain an important part of a person's identity. Through Adult Toto's return to his hometown, it explores the bittersweet feeling of remembering a past that can never fully be recovered.

Essay Questions

1. Discuss *Cinema Paradiso* as a film about memory, nostalgia, and the transformative power of cinema.

Answer Hint: Discuss Toto's life journey, themes of memory and nostalgia, the mentor-student relationship between Toto and Alfredo, the cinema as a community space, and the role of cinema in healing, preserving memories, and shaping identity.

2. Analyse Kusali Rupasinghe's review, "For the Love of Cinema," as an example of effective movie review writing. How does the review combine personal experience with critical evaluation?

Answer Hint: Explain the review's personal introduction, spoiler-free plot summary, thematic analysis, balanced use of facts and opinions, attention to details, engaging language, and effective overall evaluation of the film.